Buddha, had been born.[56] Immediately, he went to Suddhodana's palace and asked to see the child. From the auspicious marks on the child's body he knew that the infant was 'no common clay' but would attain Bodhi ('enlightenment'). His encounter with the infant is described thus:

> He took him up; and when his gaze
> found marks and signs his lore knew well
> he lifted up his voice and cried:
> 'He has no peer! He's mankind's best!'[57]

This story occurs in an early collection of discourses called the *Sutta Nipata*, a work which is part of the Buddhist tradition compiled within a hundred years of the death of the Buddha. Versions of Asita's prophecy continued into Buddhist texts for many centuries. The *Lalitavistara*, a text of the first–second centuries CE, recounted two versions of Asita's prophecy, one in prose and another in verse, which, in their main details, differ but slightly from the earlier Pali version.[58] In all instances, though, as in the case of Ashoka's coming, these are retrospective predictions made by ascetics.

In the centuries that followed, such stories about rulers came to be told most specially when recounting the life of a king who was not the first-born male child of the king or not in the existing system of primogeniture the heir to the throne. In the seventh century CE Harshavardhana's court chronicler Bana, using elaborate poetic detail, recounts that when his mother Yashovati was pregnant with Harsha, her behaviour reflected the thoughts of the future sovereign she was carrying. This was evident, we are told, in the fact that instead of jewelled mirrors she preferred to see her reflection on the blade of a sword, and instead of the lute she found pleasure in hearing the bow's twang ('ill suited to a woman', Bana says).[59]At his birth, even though he was the second son, it was predicted by an astrologer, whose advice was sought by the king, that Harsha was born at a conjunction fit for the birth of a universal emperor.